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Monterey charms with ocean views, history, seafood, and coastal trails



Map View



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With its incredible perch on Monterey Bay, the city of [Monterey](#) offers both timeless scenery and rich history. The small city enjoys a prime location on the mellow Central Coast, yet is also easy to reach from bigger metropolitan areas: It's located two hours south of [San Francisco](#), and a little more than an hour from [San Jose](#). It's also one of the prime stops on any [Highway 1 road trip](#), along with [Big Sur](#) and [Hearst Castle](#).

Monterey's Cannery Row

Begin at the heart of town—[Cannery Row](#), the waterfront district that started booming in the 1850s. Home for millennia to the Ohlone, Esselen, and Salinen tribes, immigrants from Europe and Asia settled here in the 19th century to fish the waters, with an emphasis on sardines. Thanks to the resulting canneries, Monterey became known as "Sardine Capital of the World." John Steinbeck, born and raised in nearby [Salinas](#), immortalized that era in his 1945 novel *Cannery Row*, and the



name stuck.

Today, you can still see the 19th-century architecture along the walkable blocks of this downtown

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shops. For a whimsical time-machine experience, take a spin on [Treasure Hunt: The Ride](#), an indoor ride on Cannery Row that celebrates the legend of Captain Hippolyte Bouchard, a pirate who supposedly attacked Monterey in 1818.

Old Monterey

Adjacent to Cannery Row, the Old Monterey district blends history with walkable shopping, dining, and waterfront views. Visitors can follow the [Path of History](#), marked by yellow sidewalk tiles, past 55 historic sites including Custom House—California's oldest government building and State Historic Monument No. 1—along with the Robert Louis Stevenson House and Colton Hall, where California's first constitution was drafted in 1849. Free guided tours depart Thursday through Sunday, offering deeper insight into Monterey's Spanish, Mexican, and early American eras.

The neighborhood is also home to wine tasting rooms, seafood restaurants, bookstores, and boutiques tucked along Alvarado Street and nearby side streets. Just steps from the Old Fisherman's Wharf, Old Monterey—sometimes called the Historic District—is one of the best places to get a feel for the city's layered history and coastal character.

Monterey Bay Aquarium

One building from the Cannery Row era has found its own modern-day fame: The acclaimed [Monterey Bay Aquarium](#), housed in one of those former sardine canneries, has become a leading marine life and conservation institution. In the indoor aquarium—boasting 28-foot windows—you can see jellyfish, leopard sharks, and sardines swimming in a kelp forest, and marvel at a variety of exhibits, from penguins to the giant Pacific octopus. From the aquarium's outdoor decks, you can spot sea otters, seals, and more marine life going about their lives in the [Monterey Bay National Marine Sanctuary](#), the vast federally protected area known as the "Serengeti of the Sea."

For more views, walk or [bike](#) along the 18-mile [Monterey Bay Coastal Recreation Trail](#), or head out on the water for [kayaking](#). Nearby, explore [Old Fisherman's Wharf](#), the [historic pier](#) that offers saltwater taffy, little shops, and a launching point for both [fishing excursions](#) and [whale-watching tours](#). The ever-popular destination is celebrating its 180th anniversary in 2025 with special promotions and events throughout the year.



Fun on the Water in Monterey

Monterey's coastal waters offer plenty of ways to get out on the bay, whether you prefer paddling, sailing, or heading beneath the surface. Divers flock to [San Carlos Beach](#) and [McAbee Beach](#), two popular entry points for exploring Monterey Bay's kelp forests, sea stars, and marine life. Near

Cannery Row, outfitters rent kayaks and stand-up paddleboards for excursions along the shoreline, where sea otters and harbor seals are frequent companions. Visitors can also set sail from Old Fisherman's Wharf aboard sightseeing cruises and private charters, or book deep-sea fishing trips.

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your fresh catch after the trip.

Why Is Monterey Bay Known as the "Serengeti of the Sea"?

It's not because of anything happening on land, but because of what lies beneath the water: the [Monterey Submarine Canyon](#), a mile-deep underwater canyon that begins unusually close to shore. The canyon funnels cold, nutrient-rich water toward the surface, creating one of the richest marine ecosystems in the world. That abundance of food supports an extraordinary variety of wildlife, from whales and dolphins to sea otters, sharks, seals, and massive schools of fish—helping make whale watching and marine-life sightings possible year-round.

Family-Friendly Monterey

Families visiting Monterey will find a lot geared toward younger travelers, from interactive marine exhibits to sprawling playgrounds and beaches. The aforementioned Monterey Bay Aquarium remains a must for kids, with touch pools, playful sea otters, and towering kelp forest displays, while nearby beaches offer opportunities to spot seals, sea lions, and tidepool creatures.

One of the city's most beloved family attractions is [Dennis the Menace Playground](#), a lakeside playground designed by Monterey resident and Dennis the Menace creator Hank Ketcham. The park features climbing walls, bridges, swings, slides, and wide-open spaces for running around and picnicking.

Restaurants in Monterey

You can find plenty of excellent [dining options](#) on Cannery Row or within a few blocks, such as the sustainable seafood at the Michelin-recommended Coastal Kitchen, baked goods at Alta Bakery and Cafe, and the acclaimed Italian cuisine at Montrio Bistro, housed in a 1910 firehouse.

At Old Fisherman's Wharf, stop for a scoop at Monterey Bay Creamery, lunch at Old Fisherman's Grotto (known for its chowder and Dungeness crab), or a dinner of fresh seafood with an Italian spin at Paluca Trattoria. Other top seafood restaurants in Monterey include The Fish Hopper, Monterey's Fish House, The Sardine Factory, and a branch of Chart House, to name just a few.

Where to Stay in Monterey

For overnight stays, there are several [Monterey Bay hotels and inns](#) at a wide range of price points, including several hotels with ocean views. Consider the [InterContinental The Clement Monterey](#) or the [Monterey Plaza Hotel & Spa](#), where balconies look out over the bay, or the nearby [Portola Hotel & Spa](#), which has a spa and an onsite craft brewery.



For a more intimate stay, charming bed-and-breakfasts like the Victorian-era [Jabberwock Inn](#) and the garden-filled [Old Monterey Inn](#) offer cozy rooms and easy access to downtown and Cannery Row. Travelers looking for more budget-friendly accommodations can find reliable options at spots

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Monterey's restaurants, waterfront attractions, and historic sites.

Exploring More of Monterey County

Monterey makes an excellent launching pad for more nearby gems, including the irresistible towns of [Carmel-by-the-Sea](#) and Big Sur. Visit the [National Steinbeck Center](#) in Salinas to learn more about the life and times of Steinbeck, then taste your way through [Monterey County wineries](#) and tastings rooms in Carmel-by-the-Sea and [Carmel Valley](#). Take the scenic [17-Mile Drive](#) to Pebble Beach for a round of golf on one of the famous courses, or go see the butterflies in [Pacific Grove](#).

Featured Monterey



Monterey Bay Aquarium

Whale Watching Near Monterey

Golfing Carmel



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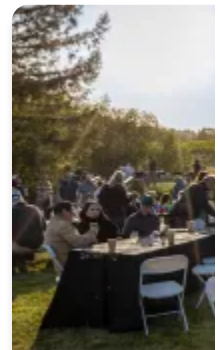
Here's How to Experience Bioluminescence in California

Finding that fascinating blue glow in the Pacific Ocean isn't easy, but it can be done



20 Unique California Events

These regional celebrations show a quirky, diverse side of the Golden State



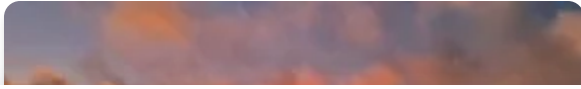
June 2026 E

Embrace su
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Events In:

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Monterey Jazz Festival

September 25–27, 2026 Catch world-class jazz in Monterey's iconic coastal setting

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Places to Eat & Drink



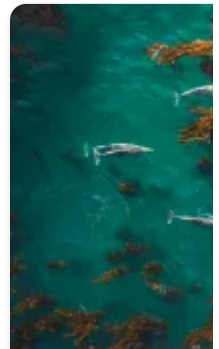
20 Unique California Events

These regional celebrations show a quirky, diverse side of the Golden State



June 2026 Events in California

Embrace summer with wine festivals, classic fairs, and live music



How to Explore the Ocean and Coast

Explore the connection between this region and the ocean.  de Podcast

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Monterey: 5 Amazing Things

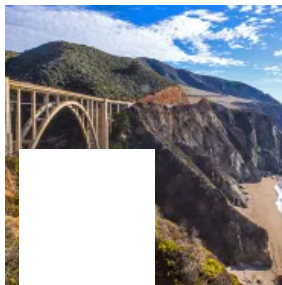


Podcasts



**ESSENTIAL TIPS FOR
CALIFORNIA ROAD TRIPS**

52 MIN



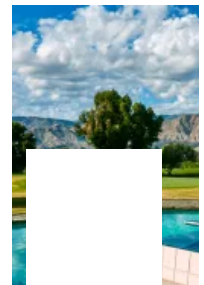
**BIG SUR, WATERFALLS,
OAKLAND**

23 MIN



**HOW TO EXPERIENCE
CALIFORNIA'S WINE**

42 MIN



**SUNNYLANDS, O
FREE ACTIVI**

31 MIN



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